

Ratatosk's Muddled Message



The snowlit fjords of the north run deep and blue between white mountains and dark green pines, dotted with cosy longhouses whose windows glow warm amber against the snow. Above them arches the Great World Tree, and on clear nights the sky dances with the colours of the aurora. The fjords are full of gentle wonders: a chattering squirrel who carries messages along the tree, two wise ravens, light spirits who dance in the dark, and frost giants who look fearsome but are mostly just cold and lonely. Here a hero is not the strongest or the loudest, but the one who keeps a warm heart, thinks things through, and shares the fire. The grandest deeds are done by being clever and brave and kind, and even a giant met with a friendly word often turns out lonelier than it is fierce.





Read aloud, or let an older child read it themselves. Pause at each question so the heroes can decide together. There are no wrong answers here, only braver ideas to try.

Before you begin

The Great World Tree holds the whole world together. Its roots reach far down into the deep dark earth, and its branches climb so high that an Eagle keeps a nest at the very top, above the snowlit fjords. All day long, a quick red squirrel named Ratatosk races up and down the trunk, carrying everyone's messages between the roots and the sky. He has never dropped one in his life. Until today.

Today Ratatosk got into such a hurry that he muddled every message up. Because of the mix-up, the great Eagle at the top of the tree now believes that a small friend down among the roots said something unkind about him. And the small friend, hearing the wrong words too, believes the Eagle said something unkind in return. Neither of them ever did. It was only a tangle of crossed messages. But the two old friends have turned their backs on each other, and the whole tree feels the chill of it.

Edda the Saga-Keeper called you to her side by the great fire of the Hearth Hall. "You have clever heads and kind hearts," she said, "and that is worth more up there than any axe. Will you help poor Ratatosk sort his messages and set things right, so the two friends make up?"

Into your hands she pressed three gifts: a ball of bright red yarn, a snack to coax a flustered squirrel, and a little lantern for the deep dark roots. "Remember," she said, "in these fjords we do not win by being the strongest. We win by being clever, brave, and kind."



What is your hero name? Which quality will you carry: Wit, Courage, or Heart?



You stepped out beneath the Great World Tree, and there was Ratatosk, a streak of red fur zooming up the trunk, round a branch, and back down again, far too flustered to stop for anyone. "Sorry, sorry, no time, all muddled, can't stop!" he chattered as he whizzed past in a blur.

He was in such a panic that he could not help a single soul, least of all himself. Before anything could be mended, he needed to slow down, catch his breath, and rest.

★ *How might you help him feel calm? You carry a snack just for him. Could you sit very still and speak in a soft, slow voice? Could you watch the way he runs and wait patiently for the right moment to offer it?*

When you held the snack out gently and spoke low and kind, Ratatosk slowed, and stopped, and finally sat. He nibbled, his quick little breaths grew steady, and his racing heart settled at last. "Oh, thank you," he sighed. "It is so much easier to think when somebody is kind to you. Now, to the muddle."



Ratatosk opened his paws and out tumbled three little messages, all jumbled together in a heap. Three friends were waiting along the tree, he explained: the fierce-looking Eagle high at the very top, a wise old owl on a middle branch, and the small friend far down among the roots. Each message belonged to just one of them. But which message went to which friend? That was the muddle.

Down swooped the Two Ravens, Thought and Memory, to perch beside you. They fly over all the fjords and forget nothing, and they do love to drop a helpful hint for heroes who are truly trying.

★ *Can you remember who lives where on the tree? Read each message carefully and hunt for the clue inside it. One message speaks of the wind and the wide sky up high. One speaks of the cool deep dark down among the roots. One simply hoots a warm and friendly hello. So which friend does each message belong to?*

When you matched every message to its right friend, the great tangle melted clean away. "That's it! That's exactly it!" cheered Ratatosk, clapping his small paws together and spinning on the spot. Now you knew precisely what to carry, and to whom each kind, true message should go.



One task remained, and it was the most important of all. The right message had to travel all the way up to the Eagle, and the right message all the way down to the small friend in the roots, so that each of them could hear the true words at last and understand.

The tree was very tall, and the way up was high and the way down was deep and dark. But you had your ball of bright red yarn.

★ *How will you climb safely without losing your way? Could you tie the red yarn at the bottom, like a safety line, and follow it up so you can always find the path back? Could you light your little lantern to see down among the deep dark roots?*

When you tied on the red yarn and climbed slowly and carefully, you came at last to the Eagle in his high nest. You read out the kind and honest message, the one that had been his all along. The Eagle's fierce frown softened into wonder. "Oh," he said quietly. "So my old friend was never unkind to me at all. It was only a muddle." Then you followed the yarn back down, down, down to the roots, your little lantern glowing, and you gave the small friend the true message too. The small friend's eyes went round and bright and happy.



High at the top of the Great World Tree, the Eagle spread his enormous wings and waved warmly down the trunk. Far below in the roots, the small friend waved right back up, and from top to bottom of the whole tree the two of them called out together, "Friends again!"

Ratatosk raced one joyful loop around the entire tree, his tail streaming behind him. "You sorted out my muddle and you mended my two friends," he said. "I will never, ever forget it. Thank you, thank you, thank you!"

High above the snowlit fjords, where the aurora ripples teal and green and purple, Freya the Kind looked down and smiled. You had done it, and you had done it together: with your wit, with your courage, and above all with your kindness. Well done, heroes of the Snowlit Fjords.

My Adventure Sheet



Draw your hero

MY NAME

I AM A HERO OF

My energy



Colour one in when you spend it

My magics

draw it

My magic is _____

It can _____

draw it

My magic is _____

It can _____

draw it

My magic is _____

It can _____

What I carry

☐ _____

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My drawing

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Wits and Wonder

Story Pack

<https://github.com/agigante80/wits-and-wonder>

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